

President Confers Padma Awards 2026



Source: PIB

Why in News?

The President of India conferred the **Padma Awards** for the year 2026 at the **Civil Investiture Ceremony-I** held at the Rashtrapati Bhavan.

What are the Key Facts About the Padma Awards?

- **Historical Structuring:** Instituted in **1954**, the awards were restructured in **1955** into three distinct, descending tiers of prestige:
 - **Padma Vibhushan** (exceptional and distinguished service; 2nd-highest civilian award after **Bharat Ratna**).
 - **Padma Bhushan** (distinguished service of high order).
 - **Padma Shri** (distinguished service in any field).
- **Constitutional Boundary (Article 18(1)):** While **Article 18(1) of the Indian Constitution abolishes all titles** and prohibits the State from conferring them on any citizen or non-citizen, it provides **explicit exceptions only for military and academic distinctions**.
- **Judicial Pronouncements :**
 - **Balaji Raghavan v. Union of India (1996):** The Supreme Court ruled that National Awards are **state recognitions of merit, not personal or hereditary titles**, and thus do not violate Article 18.
 - However, they **cannot be used as a prefix or suffix** to the recipient's name.
 - **Indira Jaising v. Supreme Court of India (2017) :** The apex court extended this logic to rule that the **designation of 'Senior Advocate' is a professional demarcation** based on proficiency, rather than a prohibited **title under Article 18**.
- **Evolution into 'People's Padma':** While open universally to all individuals regardless of race, occupation, rank, or gender (including foreigners, **NRIs**, and **OCIs**), policy shifts since **2014** have actively pivoted toward honoring **"unsung heroes" at the grassroots level**.
 - However, government servants (including those working with PSUs), except doctors and scientists, are not eligible for these awards while in service.
- **Selection Process:** The **Padma Awards Committee** is constituted annually by the **Prime Minister** and is chaired by the **Cabinet Secretary**, with the Home Secretary, Secretary to the President, and 4-6

eminent persons as members.

- The Committee selects awardees based on **lifetime achievement, public service, and the principle of “excellence plus,” rather than mere long service.**
- Its recommendations are submitted to the **Prime Minister and the President of India for final approval.**
- Padma Awards are announced annually on the **eve of Republic Day** and formally conferred by the **President of India in March/April**, with recipients receiving a **Sanad (certificate), medallion, and replica**.
- **Statutory Caps and Regulations:** The total number of awards is **capped at a maximum of 120 per year** (excluding posthumous awards and non-citizen recipients like NRIs/foreigners).
 - A higher category Padma award is only granted after **at least five years since the previous Padma award.**
 - Padma Awards are normally not conferred posthumously, but the Government may consider them in highly deserving cases.
- **Historical Suspensions:** The conferment of these national honors has been disrupted twice in independent India's history:
 - **1978-79** (under the Morarji Desai-led Janata Party government) and **1993-97** (due to the pending constitutional litigation in the *Balaji Raghavan* case).



CIVILIAN AND GALLANTRY AWARDS

CIVILIAN AWARDS

Bharat Ratna

- India's highest civilian award; instituted in 1954
- Awarded for exceptional service/performance of the highest order in any field of human endeavour
- Award includes certificate & medallion (no monetary grant)
- Recommended to President by the PM
- Can be given (max) thrice per year

Padma Awards

- Instituted in 1954; announced annually on eve of Republic Day
- Recognises achievements in all fields/disciplines involving public service
- Categories: Padma Vibhushan > Padma Bhushan > Padma Shri
- Recommended by Padma Awards Committee (constituted by PM annually)
- Suspended twice - 1978-79 and 1993-97
- Max no. of awards per year - 120



GALLANTRY AWARDS

- Wartime Gallantry instituted on 26th January 1950
- Peacetime Gallantry instituted on 4th January 1952
- Announced twice a year - Republic Day and Independence Day
- Order of Precedence - Param Vir Chakra > Ashoka Chakra > Mahavir Chakra > Kirti Chakra > Vir Chakra > Shaurya Chakra

Eligibility -

- All officers of all ranks (Army, Navy, IAF), Reserve forces, Territorial army
- People providing nursing services under any of the above forces

Wartime Gallantry Awards



Param Vir Chakra



Maha Vir Chakra



Vir Chakra

Peacetime Gallantry Awards



Ashoka Chakra



Kirti Chakra



Shaurya Chakra




Drishti IAS

Frequently Asked Questions (FAQs)

1. What are the Padma Awards?

The Padma Awards are among the highest civilian honours in India, presented annually to recognize distinguished and exceptional achievements or service in various fields.

2. What are the three categories of Padma Awards?

They are Padma Vibhushan, Padma Bhushan, and Padma Shri, in descending order of prestige.

3. Why do Padma Awards not violate Article 18?

The Supreme Court held in *Balaji Raghavan v. Union of India* that they are state recognitions of merit, not hereditary or prohibited titles.

4. Who selects the Padma Award recipients?

A Padma Awards Committee, chaired by the Cabinet Secretary and appointed annually by the Prime Minister, prepares the recommendations for final approval.

[Watch Video on YouTube:

▶ <https://www.youtube.com/embed/AujrVznTzXg>

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UPSC Civil Services Examination, Previous Year Questions (PYQs)

Q. Consider the following statements in respect of Bharat Ratna and Padma Awards: (2021)

1. Bharat Ratna and Padma Awards are titles under the Article 18(1) of the Constitution of India.
2. Padma Awards, which were instituted in the year 1954, were suspended only once.
3. The number of Bharat Ratna Awards is restricted to a maximum of five in a particular year.

Which of the above statements are not correct?

- (a) 1 and 2 only
- (b) 2 and 3 only
- (c) 1 and 3 only
- (d) 1, 2 and 3

Ans: (d)

I4C Alert on Apple iPhone Phishing Scam



Source: TH

The **National Cybercrime Threat Analytics Unit** of the **Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C)** has issued an advisory warning of a sophisticated phishing campaign targeting Apple iPhone users whose devices are lost or stolen.

- I4C functions under the **Ministry of Home Affairs** and works to strengthen India's coordinated response against cybercrime. It supports threat analytics, public advisories, cybercrime reporting and coordination among law enforcement agencies.

Phishing

- **About:** Phishing is a cyberattack in which fraudsters **use fake emails, text messages, phone calls or websites** to trick people into sharing sensitive information.
- **Nature:** It is a form of **social engineering that exploits human trust, urgency, fear, or error rather than** directly attacking computer systems.
- **Method:** Attackers usually **impersonate trusted individuals, organisations, authorities, or brands and ask victims to click links, open attachments, make payments,** or share credentials.
- **Impact:** Phishing can lead to **theft of login details, bank information or personal data, installation of malware or ransomware** , and financial or organisational harm.

- **Type:** In **smishing** , phishing is done through SMS, while in **vishing** , attackers use voice calls to deceive users.



Read More: [Cyber Attacks](#)

Hutti Gold Mines



Source:TH

The **Hutti Gold Mine** in Karnataka, which is currently India's only fully functional, state-owned **gold** mine, has reported a significant windfall in its revenues. This profit surge is primarily driven by the **soaring gold prices in the international market** , which have reached record highs due to global economic and geopolitical factors.

- **Hutti Gold Mines Limited (HGML)**

- **Location:** Situated in the Raichur district of Karnataka.
- **Operational Status:** It operates under the Government of Karnataka and is the sole public sector unit producing gold through continuous underground mining in India.

- **Historical Significance:** Mining in the Hutti region traces back to the **pre-Ashokan era**.
 - The first wave of modern, deep-level exploration was spearheaded by John Taylor & Sons under the aegis of the Nizam of Hyderabad's Hyderabad (Deccan) Company.
 - Following the reorganization of states in 1956, the entity was renamed and integrated under the Government of Mysore (now Karnataka), carrying the legacy forward after the **closure of the famous Kolar Gold Fields (KGF) in 2000**.
- **Production Volume:** Hutti currently produces roughly **1.5 to 2 tonnes of gold annually**.
- **Trading Mechanisms:** The company sells '**Gold Dore Bars**' (unrefined gold containing impurities) to refiners based on the weekly average rates of the **India Bullion and Jewellers Association (IBJA)**, which differs from standard retail trading costs.
- **Status of Gold Mining in India**
 - **Consumption vs. Production:** India is the **second-largest consumer of gold globally** (averaging ~800 tonnes annually), largely driven by cultural affinity and investment demand.
 - However, domestic production meets less than **1%** of this demand.
- **Geographical Distribution of Reserves:**
 - **Karnataka:** Holds the lion's share of India's gold reserves (Hutti, Uti, and the defunct KGF).
 - **Andhra Pradesh:** Ramagiri in Anantapur and the newly operational **Jonnagiri Gold Fields** in Kurnool.
 - Jonnagiri is India's first large-scale private gold mine since Independence.
 - **Other States:** Minor deposits are found in Rajasthan, Bihar, Jharkhand, and Kerala.
- **Economic Impact of Imports:** The massive gap between supply and demand results in a colossal import bill (approx. USD 72 billion in FY26), which heavily burdens India's **Current Account Deficit (CAD)** and foreign exchange reserves.
- **Global Gold Production:** China was the largest producer in the world in 2024, and the largest gold mining complex in the world is the **Nevada Gold Mines complex in the US**.

Largest gold mines in the world

Rank	Mine	Country
1	Nevada Gold Mines	USA
2	Muruntau	Uzbekistan
3	Olimpiada	Russia
4	Kazzinc Consolidated	Kazakhstan
5	Grasberg	Indonesia
6	Almalyk Complex	Uzbekistan
7	Blagodatnoye	Russia
8	Detour Lake	Canada
9	Kibali	DR Congo
10	Ahafo	Ghana

Read more: [RBI's Strategic Gold Repatriation](#)

Memflation Impact on India's Electronics Sector



Source: TH

Driven by the exponential demand for **AI infrastructure**, a global structural shift in **semiconductor manufacturing** has triggered severe '**memflation**', causing acute supply shortages and price escalations in India's highly price-sensitive consumer electronics market.

- **The Phenomenon of 'Memflation':** It refers to the **inflationary pressure caused by an acute shortage of conventional memory chips**, specifically **DRAM (Dynamic Random-Access Memory)** used for temporary processor storage, and **NAND** flash (a type of non-volatile storage technology that allows to retain data without needing a constant power source).
- **Supply Chain Diversion** : Major global semiconductor fabricators are aggressively reallocating their advanced packaging and wafer capacities toward **High-Bandwidth Memory (HBM)** to support intensive **AI infrastructure and data centers** .
 - Crucially, manufacturing **one HBM unit consumes 2-3 times the wafer capacity** of a conventional DRAM unit, starving the supply of standard chips for consumer electronics.
- **Impact on the Indian Smartphone Market:** The shortage of standard memory chips has increased the retail prices of several mobile phone brands in India by nearly 15–20%, severely affecting the country's highly price-sensitive smartphone market.
 - Global chipmakers are prioritising premium brands such as Apple and Samsung for standard memory allocation, leaving budget smartphone makers in India under supply pressure, **increasing Bill of Materials (BOM) costs** and pushing manufacturers toward higher-value devices.
- **India's Strategic Vulnerability:** According to the **India Electronics & Semiconductor Association (IESA)**, India remains highly vulnerable to global semiconductor supply disruptions due to its heavy dependence on imported semiconductor components, particularly from China, and the still-developing nature of its domestic **Electronics System Design and Manufacturing (ESDM)** ecosystem.
 - Industry forecasts indicate that 'memflation' will **persistently tighten the market through 2026-2027** .
 - This cycle threatens to **destroy or delay non-AI technological demand** and IT procurement until highly capital-intensive global capacity expansions begin yielding results by 2028.

Read more: [Semiconductor Industry in India](#)

RBI Forms Q-SAFE Committee



Source: TH

Recently, the **Reserve Bank of India (RBI)** constituted an eight-member Expert Committee for a **Quantum Secure and Adaptive Financial Ecosystem (Q-SAFE)** to explore the benefits, risks and challenges of quantum technology in the financial sector.

- **Rationale: Quantum Technology** uses principles of quantum mechanics such as **superposition and entanglement**, enabling solutions for complex financial problems like portfolio optimisation, risk assessment and macroeconomic modelling.
- **Key Risk:** Quantum technology may undermine existing cryptographic standards, creating security risks for banking, payments and the wider financial ecosystem.
- **Mandate:** The committee will evaluate the financial sector's cryptographic inventory through a **Cryptography Bill of Materials (CBOM)** and assess crypto agility.
 - Crypto agility is the **ability of a system to quickly shift from vulnerable cryptographic methods** to safer alternatives without major disruption.
- **Vulnerability Mapping:** It will identify critical financial systems and processes that may be vulnerable to **quantum-related cyber threats**.
- **Preparedness and Regulation:** The panel will **assess industry readiness for quantum-safe cryptography**, including vendor tools, and undertake cross-country analysis of regulatory frameworks for safe quantum deployment.
- **Timeline:** The committee will recommend a roadmap to quantum-secure India's financial system and submit its **report within six months of its first meeting**.



Read More: [Ultra-Secure Communication Using Quantum Technology](#)

